ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 242: Costume and Appearance Design - Stage, Screen and Carnival

Dress a character with intention, from festival spectacle to film close-up

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Costume is character information made visible. This pack covers research and period sources, colour and silhouette, fabric behaviour under stage light and camera, make-up for stage versus screen, and the workflow from sketch to fitting to wardrobe maintenance.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Research and document a period or cultural costume source responsibly.
- Design costumes that communicate character, status and period.
- Distinguish stage make-up from screen make-up technique.
- Manage a wardrobe plot, fittings and maintenance for a production.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Research and concept

Design begins with evidence, not mood boards alone.

- Identify the period, region, class and occasion of the production.
- Collect primary sources: photographs, museum catalogues, archival images.
- Note what a fabric, dye or accessory would actually have been available.
- Avoid mixing culturally distinct dress traditions into a generic 'African' look.
- Write a concept statement linking costume choices to character and theme.
- Credit your sources in a design file.

> **Specific, not decorative**
> A faded collar tells the audience about money. A random bright scarf tells them nothing.

Colour, silhouette and light

Costume must read from the back row and survive a close-up.

- Silhouette communicates status and period before detail is visible.
- Colour reads differently under tungsten, LED and daylight.
- Pattern can vibrate on camera; test on screen before approval.
- Fabric weight affects movement, heat and sound.
- Contrast separates a character from the set; blending creates anonymity.
- Test make-up under the actual lighting plot, not a bathroom mirror.

Workflow and wardrobe

A costume department is logistics as much as art.

- Costume plot: every character, scene and change listed in a table.
- Measurements, fittings and alteration schedules.
- Budget per character and per scene; track receipts.
- Quick-change plans and dressers for fast transitions.
- Maintenance: cleaning, repairs, labelling and storage.
- Returns, hires and security of borrowed items.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 242

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 242 Costume and Appearance Designs: From Festive Spectacle to Carnival
- History of costuming and make-up through the ages; textiles, cosmetology and fashion trends
- Sketching, match-ups, fittings, highlights, accessories and finishing

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 242 Costume and Appearance Designs, 3 credits, second semester, 200 level
- THA 344 Costume and Make-Up Design for the Stage and Screen follows at 300 level
- Costume sits within the technology and design stress area

What changed: The 2019 listing adds THA 344, extending costume design explicitly to screen work.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Costume and appearance design remains the 200-level design core
- Screen make-up is now likely to be assessed given the film track
- Confirm whether materials are provided or self-funded for practicals

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is a costume plot?

Answer: A table listing each character's costume for each scene, including changes, accessories and responsible crew.

2. Why must costume be tested under stage lighting?

Answer: Colour and texture shift under different light sources, so a costume that reads well in daylight may disappear on stage.

3. Give two differences between stage and screen make-up.

Answer: Stage make-up is heavier and more defined to read at distance; screen make-up is finer and controlled for close-ups and camera colour.

4. Why is cultural specificity important in design?

Answer: It communicates accurately and respectfully, avoiding the flattening of distinct traditions into a generic aesthetic.

5. What should a quick-change plan include?

Answer: The change, timing, dresser assignment, garment preparation and a rehearsal of the change.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Build a research file with five primary sources.
- [ ] Write a concept statement for one character.
- [ ] Draw two costume sketches with fabric swatches.
- [ ] Create a costume plot for a short play.
- [ ] Test make-up under stage lighting and photograph it.
- [ ] Cost your design and list hire items.
- [ ] Rehearse one quick change with a dresser.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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